

The Morning Briefing

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FOR MARCUS JOHNSON
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WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 12, 2026 — U.S. POLITICS · JUDICIARY · ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST · VATICAN · WORLD · LONG READS

THE LEAD STORY

U.S. Navy Strikes Panamanian Vessel Enforcing Iran Blockade as Hormuz Diplomacy Intensifies

U.S. forces struck a Panamanian-flagged vessel in the Gulf of Oman on August 11 over an alleged breach of the naval blockade on Iran, transferring the crew to another ship before the strike, a U.S. official told the Wall Street Journal. The same day, Germany's foreign minister told Iranian counterpart Abbas Araghchi that the Strait of Hormuz must open, and Pakistan's defense minister said the U.S. and Iran are nearing "some sort of an arrangement" toward a longer-term peace deal. The blockade enforcement, not any Israeli action, is the proximate cause of the week's sharpest U.S. military escalation in the Gulf — a reminder that Washington now owns significant operational risk in a theater whose deepest stakes are frequently described as Israel's. Full analysis in Israel & the Middle East, below.

U.S. POLITICS

PRIMARIES

Tuesday's Results Expose Fault Lines in Both Parties

Tuesday primaries exposed the fault lines inside both parties ahead of November. In Wisconsin, Milwaukee County Executive David Crowley narrowly beat democratic socialist Francesca Hong in the Democratic gubernatorial primary. In Minnesota, progressive Lt. Gov. Peggy Flanagan won the Democratic Senate primary, extending a run of wins for the party's left flank over centrists, while on the Republican side state House Speaker Lisa Demuth beat MyPillow founder Mike Lindell by double digits in the GOP governor's race. In South Carolina, Rep. Ralph Norman was one of two top vote-getters in a crowded GOP Senate primary and now heads to a runoff.

WHY IT MATTERS

Lindell's blowout loss and Norman's forced runoff both read as establishment-over-insurgent results — the opposite of the story national Republicans have told about the party since 2024.

NPR Politics — npr.org/sections/politics

CONGRESS

Senate Gavels In, Gavels Out, Heads to Recess

The Senate met in a pro forma session on August 12 and immediately adjourned until Thursday, August 13, formalizing its August recess. No floor votes are expected until members return.

Congress.gov — congress.gov/on-senate-floor-today

JUDICIARY & SCOTUS

BIRTHRIGHT CITIZENSHIP

Trump Signs New Orders Targeting Birthright Citizenship, Weeks After Losing at the Court

Six weeks after the Supreme Court struck down the administration's attempt to end birthright citizenship as a violation of the 14th Amendment, President Trump has signed new executive orders again targeting birthright citizenship — the second attempt at the same goal after a direct constitutional loss.

ANALYTICAL READ

Re-litigating a right the Court already settled by executive order, rather than through Congress, tests how far the administration can push before the Court treats it as defiance rather than a new question.

NPR — npr.org/2026/08/06/g-s1-137686

THE DOCKET

Court Sets August 17 Orders, Awaits Transgender-Service Petition

The Court has orders scheduled for August 17 and a conference set for August 28; the interim docket shows 51 cases already decided this term against 3 still pending. The administration is expected to file a petition by August 30 seeking review of the policy disqualifying servicemembers with a history of gender dysphoria. Separately, another prominent Democrat has voiced support for expanding the Court, and the Court's approval rating has hit a new low.

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

GULF ESCALATION

U.S. Strikes Vessel Over Iran Blockade Breach; Hormuz Diplomacy Advances

U.S. forces struck a Panamanian-flagged vessel in the Gulf of Oman on August 11 over an alleged breach of the naval blockade on Iran; a U.S. official told the Wall Street Journal the crew was transferred to another ship and all were accounted for. The strike came the same day Germany's foreign minister told Iranian counterpart Abbas Araghchi that the Strait of Hormuz must open, and as Pakistan's defense minister said the U.S. and Iran are nearing "some sort of an arrangement" toward a longer-term peace deal.

ANALYTICAL READ

Washington, not Jerusalem, is running the point on blockade enforcement and peace-track diplomacy here — worth noting given how often the ceasefire architecture from this spring's war gets credited to Israel. A U.S. vessel firing on a third-flag ship over a blockade it polices is a U.S. risk and a U.S. escalation, regardless of whose war aims the blockade was set up to serve.

Jerusalem Post — jpost.com/middle-east/iran-news/2026-08-11/live-updates-905132

SYRIA / NONPROLIFERATION

Syria Distances Itself From Israeli Role in IAEA Nuclear-Material Deal

Syria says the IAEA will announce "significant progress" on removing nuclear material from the country under a deal reached with the U.S. and Israel; a Syrian official told Reuters pointedly that "there is no Israeli role in this process."

ANALYTICAL READ

A Syrian official volunteering that Israel had no role is itself a signal — Damascus is managing its own public perception of the deal, suggesting Israeli involvement is a liability for Syria's new government even where it serves shared U.S.-Israeli nonproliferation interests.

Jerusalem Post — jpost.com/middle-east/article-905216

IRAQ / LEBANON

Rocket Hits Kurdish Opposition Camp Near Erbil; Lebanon Pilot Zones Expand

A rocket attack hit an Iranian-Kurdish opposition camp near Erbil, Iraq; security sources blamed Iran, with no casualties reported. Israel and the U.S. also finalized plans to expand joint pilot zones in southern Lebanon under the U.S.-brokered framework meant to restore Lebanese sovereignty and disarm Hezbollah, with the next round of Israel-Lebanon talks set for September.

Times of Israel — timesofisrael.com/latest

KNESSET POLITICS

Netanyahu Tightens Grip on Likud List Ahead of Next Election

Prime Minister Netanyahu tightened his grip on Likud's parliamentary list, adding reserved slots for Gideon Sa'ar and Yisrael Katz; he now personally controls 11 of the top 29 slots on the list.

WHY IT MATTERS

List consolidation ahead of an eventual election concentrates Netanyahu's leverage over his own coalition at the same moment Israel is deep into a U.S.-mediated regional settlement. The two are not unrelated: a freer hand at home makes it easier either to sell concessions abroad or to resist them.

Jerusalem Post — jpost.com

ITALY, ROME & THE VATICAN

GENERAL AUDIENCE

Pope Leo: The Liturgical Year Renews Christ's Saving Work

At his Wednesday General Audience in St. Peter's Basilica, Pope Leo XIV continued his catechetical cycle on the Second Vatican Council's constitution *Sacrosanctum Concilium*, focusing on chapter five and the liturgical year. Drawing on Pope Pius XII and Pope St. John Paul II, Leo said the liturgical year should be understood not as "a lifeless recollection of events from the past" but as the ongoing renewal of Christ's saving work, with Sunday as its "foundation and kernel" and the weekly Easter. He said the Sunday assembly "cannot be substituted by a solely virtual presence" and urged parishes to find ways for those who must work Sundays to still attend Mass.

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-at-audience-the-liturgical-year-renews-christ-s-saving-work.html

MAGNIFICA HUMANITAS

World Day of Peace Theme Draws on Encyclical: "Artificial Intelligence Must Be Disarmed"

The Dicastery for the Service of Integral Human Development announced the theme for the 60th World Day of Peace (January 1, 2027): "Disarming Technology, Serving Peace: Politics as Preventive Responsibility." The theme draws directly on Pope Leo's encyclical *Magnifica Humanitas*, promulgated May 25 in the New Synod Hall — an unprecedented, nearly 200-page document devoted to AI and new technology. Citing paragraph 198 — "there is no algorithm capable of making war morally acceptable" — the Pope has called for artificial intelligence used in military decision-making to be "disarmed," in the same sense the Church has long called for nuclear disarmament, saying "decisions about technology must never be separated from conscience and responsibility."

WHY IT MATTERS

This is one of the more concrete magisterial interventions yet on AI and autonomous weapons. Leo is explicitly analogizing algorithmic warfare to nuclear weapons and asking states to apply the same disarmament framework, putting the Holy See on record well ahead of most national governments.

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/60th-world-day-of-peace-theme-disarming-technology-for-peace.html

COLOMBIA

Pope Prays for Colombia Earthquake Victims, Publishes San Marino-Rimini Itinerary

The Vatican published Pope Leo's programme for his visit to San Marino and Rimini. The Pope also sent prayers for victims of the earthquake in Manizales, Colombia, where one tower of the city's cathedral collapsed; Colombian bishops appealed for solidarity.

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-prays-for-victims-of-colombia-earthquake-asks-for-closeness.html

WORLD NEWS

ROUNDUP

"Fighting Rages From Ukraine to the Middle East," Vatican News Says

Vatican News' own roundup on August 11 was headlined "Fighting rages from Ukraine to the Middle East," grouping the Iran-Gulf escalation with continued Russia-Ukraine fighting as the week's dominant global security story.

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/world/news/2026-08/fighting-rages-from-ukraine-to-the-middle-east.html

LEBANON

Rome-Hosted Lebanon Talks Reported to Be Making Progress

Talks on Lebanon's political and security future continued in Rome this week, with reports suggesting progress toward a framework acceptable to both Beirut and the U.S.-Israel side.

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/world/news/2026-08/lebanon-talks-in-rome-making-progress-reports-suggest.html

RESEARCH & LONG READS

THE AMERICAN RIGHT

The American Right, Mid-Fracture

The Washington Examiner's Restoring America project is launching "The Right Way Forward," a debate series pitting conservative think tanks against each other on the questions splitting the post-Trump right, starting with the state's role in the economy. Senior editor Peter Laffin's framing essay leans on political scientist James Ceaser's "Four Heads and One Heart" thesis — that conservative unity has always rested on shared opposition to the left rather than shared principle — and argues that with the left diminished, traditionalists, neoconservatives, libertarians, and the religious right no longer have enough holding them together. Laffin draws a parallel to the 1950s Kirk-Meyer feud that produced "fusionism" and built the Reagan coalition, and argues the current infighting could do the same if channeled into real argument rather than purges.

ANALYTICAL READ

Worth reading against Tuesday's primary results. Lisa Demuth beating Mike Lindell by double digits and Ralph Norman being forced into a runoff are exactly the kind of factional friction Laffin describes, playing out in real votes rather than essays.

Washington Examiner — washingtonexaminer.com/premium/4558270/conservatives-discuss-debate-future-after-trump

CATHOLIC APOLOGETICS

Defending Papal Primacy, From Scripture and the Fathers

Jeffrey Mirus's essay "The Authority of the Pope" (Catholic Culture, drawn from his book *Reasons for Hope*) lays out the classic apologetic case for Petrine succession and papal infallibility: Peter's scriptural pre-eminence among the apostles (Matthew 16, John 21), the unbroken patristic record of Roman primacy being taken for granted from Clement of Rome onward, and the ecclesiological argument that a vicariate implies a line of successors. Mirus also addresses the standard objections — that a heretical pope forfeits authority, that Vatican I's 1870 definition of infallibility was a novelty — and rebuts both from the historical record.

WHY IT MATTERS

Useful primary-source apologetics to have on hand the same week the Vatican is making an unusually assertive doctrinal intervention in Magnifica Humanitas. The argument for why the papal teaching office carries binding weight underlies both stories.

Catholic Culture — catholicculture.org/culture/library/view.cfm?id=4319